Mehrdad Pourghasem

PhD Candidate in Economics, Pennsylvania State University

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Research Interests

Industrial Organization, Health Economics, and Applied Microeconomics

Education

PhD in Economics, Pennsylvania State University, USA — 2022–2028 (expected)
Fields: Industrial Organization, Health Economics
Dissertation: *Who Chooses the Hospital? Insurers' Referral Steering and Hospital Prices*
Advisors: Conor Ryan and Paul Grieco; Committee: Bradley Setzler, David Vanness

MSc in Economics, Sharif University of Technology, Iran — 2019–2022
Thesis: *Road Infrastructure and Agricultural Outcomes*; ranked 1st in cumulative GPA in cohort

BSc in Industrial Engineering, Sharif University of Technology, Iran — 2014–2019

Research

Insurer Steering Through Primary Care Physicians: Effects on Hospital Demand, Prices, and Welfare. *Job Market Paper (Preliminary Draft)*

- Examines how insurer control of PCP referral networks changes hospital demand, negotiated prices, and welfare.
- Develops and estimates a structural model in which PCP referral behavior determines hospital demand, with hospital–insurer prices set through Nash-in-Nash bargaining.
- Uses 2018–2023 California claims and admissions data, exploiting variation in the timing of PCP contract transitions to capitation, to quantify the pass-through from referral control to prices and the spending–quality tradeoff in steering.

Why Pay-for-Performance Failed to Move the Needle: A Structural Model of Incentive Pass-Through in the U.S. Dialysis Industry. *Working Paper (Preliminary Draft)*

- Explains why ETC, a large mandatory randomized pay-for-performance program launched in January 2021, produced a near-zero reduced-form effect on home dialysis.
- Builds a facility-year panel covering roughly 9,000 U.S. dialysis facilities using public CMS and cost-report data.
- Estimates a structural model that decomposes the null effect into patient eligibility constraints, facility capacity/investment costs, and chain-level optimization across markets, and uses the model to evaluate policy counterfactuals including patient-support interventions, capacity subsidies, and payment-rate escalation.

Heterogeneous Willingness-to-Pay for Electric Vehicles. *3rd Year Paper*

- Merges U.S. market-level auto sales data (Ward's) with household-level purchase data (CEX) and detailed vehicle attributes.
- Estimates random-coefficients logit demand (BLP) with demographic interactions and micro-moments to recover heterogeneous willingness-to-pay.
- Documents substantial heterogeneity: higher EV valuations among urban and college-educated households, and stronger baseline EV disutility among rural, low-income, and non-college-educated households.

Road Infrastructure & Agricultural Outcomes. *MSc Thesis*

- Constructs a county-level panel for Iran linking village road access to farmland rental rates (2006 and 2011).
- Uses fixed-effects estimation and ArcGIS spatial analysis to evaluate impacts on local land values and agricultural outcomes.

Teaching Experience

Instructor, Pennsylvania State University — Summer 2025
Introduction to Macroeconomic Analysis and Policy; enrollment: 38 students.

Teaching Assistant, Pennsylvania State University — Fall 2022–Present
Courses: International Finance, Advanced International Trade.

Teaching Assistant, Sharif University of Technology — Fall 2017–Fall 2021

Courses: Energy Economics, Game Theory, Principles of Economics, System Dynamics.

Professional Experience

Research Analyst Oct 2019–Dec 2020
Morvarid Petrochemical Company, Tehran, Iran
- Led a four-member team to translate broad strategic questions into a research plan with clear milestones in collaboration with the CEO.
- Built a dynamic forecasting model linking macroeconomic indicators to output and profitability.
- Synthesized quantitative and qualitative findings into executive presentations with actionable operational and risk recommendations.

Research Analyst Oct 2017–Dec 2018
Iranian Water Policy Research Institute, Tehran, Iran
- Evaluated regional water-market design alternatives using field interviews and international case-study evidence.
- Quantified impacts of alternative water allocation policies using statistical models.
- Presented findings to 100+ stakeholders at a multi-day Chamber of Commerce forum.

Research Analyst Jul 2017–Sep 2017
Urmia Lake Restoration Commission, Tehran, Iran
- Gathered and documented business requirements for three startup initiatives and translated needs into technical specifications.

Business Analyst Jul 2016–Jul 2017
Smartup Ventures, Tehran, Iran
- Conducted market research and feasibility analyses for three startup ventures.
- Promoted to CEO Assistant within six months; coordinated cross-functional teams for rebranding and website launch.

Technical Skills

Programming and Analysis: Python (pandas, NumPy, PyBLP), R, Stata, SQL, LaTeX
Economics and Econometrics: Structural estimation (BLP demand, Nash-in-Nash bargaining, merger simulation); causal inference (difference-in-differences, IV, event study); panel data; large administrative claims data
Data and Visualization: ArcGIS, Tableau, Power BI
Languages: English, Persian

Honors and Awards

- Ranked 1st in Cumulative GPA among Economics (Energy Economics) students, Sharif University of Technology, 2019–2021
- Top 0.5% among 10,000+ participants in the Nationwide University Entrance Exam for MSc in Economics, 2019
- Top 0.5% among 40,000+ participants in the Mathematics and Physics Nationwide University Entrance Exam (Konkur)

Extracurricular Activities

Sharif University of Technology
- Executive Director, Student Guild Council
- Member, Swimming Team

References

Conor Ryan (Advisor)
Assistant Professor of Economics
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Paul Grieco (Advisor)
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Bradley Setzler (Committee)
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